

Meeting Name:	Cabinet
Date:	6 January 2026
Report title:	Social Purpose of Land Framework
Cabinet Member:	Councillor Helen Dennis, New Homes and Sustainable Development
Ward(s) or groups affected:	All
Classification:	Open
Reason for lateness (if applicable):	N/a

FOREWORD – COUNCILLOR HELEN DENNIS, CABINET MEMBER FOR NEW HOMES AND SUSTAINABLE DEVELOPMENT

I'm delighted to be bringing this report which recommends moving forward with several key actions arising from the Southwark Land Commission, which was set up by this administration to explore how we maximise public good from public land. One of the key proposals made by the Commissioners was to develop a 'Social Purpose of Land Framework' which would help guide decision-making around council land and assets, with the potential for wider applicability to other landowners in the future.

Earlier this year, the council commissioned the New Economics Foundation (NEF) to help us develop a draft framework, using the principles of community organising to ensure that the model would have local resonance and be embedded within the community going forward. Funded by the Greater London Authority (GLA), NEF's draft framework is attached to this report and provides a template that we can now pilot across four Southwark sites, three of which are council-owned, and one of which has been nominated by the Anglican Diocese.

The Social Purpose of Land Framework will seek to increase transparency around decision-making and to bring forward a new process in partnership with the local community. Neighbourhood Land Panels will be established around each of the pilot sites, and will seek to engage a wide and representative range of voices in discussions, exploring options that take account of neighbourhood and boroughwide priorities, and assessing their feasibility. We will be investing in this process using unallocated reserves and plan to tweak the model across the different sites to take account of the different contexts, and to test and learn from the different approaches.

In addition, this report also enables the establishment of a Southwark Land Partnership, which will bring together key landowners across the borough to help release sites for common priorities, maximising social value including the delivery of genuinely affordable housing, thriving high streets and improved green spaces.

I want to thank everyone who has been involved in this ground-breaking work including all of the Land Commissioners, Miatta Fahnbulleh as Chair, Councillor James McAsh who led the original process from cabinet, and staff at the NEF I am

incredibly excited by this next step and to seeing what ideas might now emerge from the community that will enable us to better use the built environment to achieve our Southwark 2030 goals.

RECOMMENDATIONS

Recommendations for the Cabinet

That Cabinet:

1. Approve the implementation of the Social Purpose of Land Framework ('the Framework') pilot phase as set out in Section 4 and 5 (page 39 to 50 of **Appendix 1 – Social Purpose of Land Framework a Proposal from The New Economics Foundation**, and paragraph 26 of this report, on four (4) council-identified sites as set out in paragraph 59.
2. Note that a revised Framework will be brought back to cabinet following the pilot phase for further consideration.
3. Delegates the approval of any minor non-substantive amendments resulting from its meeting and a final review by officers on the framework to the director of planning and growth in consultation with the cabinet member for new homes and sustainable development prior to final release.
4. Delegates authority to the director of planning and growth to oversee implementation and refinement of the framework processes, including the development of an action plan supporting the framework.
5. Establish the Southwark Land Partnership (SLP) in accordance with the Terms of Reference in **Appendix 3** and delegate authority to the director of planning and growth to finalise governance arrangements and partnership agreements.
6. To consider whether to issue early notice of the intention to dispose of council's owned land or buildings at the time of reviewing the asset management plan.
7. Agrees an allocation of £500,000 of reserve funding towards the costs of informing and resourcing the pilot sites of the Social Purpose of Land Framework.

Recommendations for the Leader of the Council

8. Vary the executive scheme of delegation to delegate authority to the cabinet member for new homes and sustainable development to approve the details of the fifth pilot site, in accordance with paragraph 60 of this report.

REASONS FOR RECOMMENDATIONS

9. In 2022, Southwark Council launched the Southwark Land Commission, which was the first of its kind in London, to explore how land in our borough could better serve the needs of local people. Made up of community leaders,

landowners, and experts, the Commission spent several months seeking feedback from residents, reviewing evidence, and making recommendations for improvement.

10. Based on this work, the Land Commission developed the Land for Good report, published towards the end of 2023, which called for a bold shift: to put social purpose at the heart of how land and public assets are used and managed. The report outlined 7 headline recommendations, the first of which was to “Put Social Purpose at the Heart of Land Use” with a proposal to establish a “Social Purpose of Land Framework” which would ultimately be applied to all land and property use decisions by participating landowners. Other linked recommendations included:
 - Recommendation 3 of the Action Plan included the commitment to no net loss of public and community owned land, and for all disposals to be considered through the Social Purpose Framework.
 - Recommendation 6 of the Action Plan included an action to bring together participating landowners into a SLP, committed to freeing up land for the public good through the Social Purpose of Land Framework.
 - Recommendation 7 of the Action Plan included an action to identify 2 council owned pilot sites and encourage stakeholders to bring forward a further 4 sites.
11. In response to the Southwark Land Commission’s recommendations, the Council committed to exploring new models of land governance that embed community voice and deliver long-term social outcomes. The New Economics Foundation (NEF) was commissioned to develop the Framework, which proposes a structured, participatory process for evaluating and shaping land use decisions.
12. This framework provides a practical tool to implement this recommendation and commitment made by council, ensuring that land owned by the council is used in ways that prioritise public good, community benefit, and long-term social outcomes.
13. This framework outlines the overarching principles and process used as part of a community engagement tool to ensure social benefits are an integral part of how proposals for the use of land are developed with regard to the use of land. This framework seeks to provide a process that is responsive to the needs and aspirations of Southwark’s diverse communities while also considering council resources.
14. This report also seeks to establish the SLP to support the facilitation of the Framework and overseeing its progress.

ALTERNATIVE OPTIONS CONSIDERED AND NOT RECOMMENDED

Do not produce a Social Purpose of Land Framework; continue with existing processes

15. This Framework ensures that every decision we make helps move us closer to the Southwark 2030 goals, including tackling inequality, responding to the climate emergency, or empowering communities to shape their neighbourhoods. The Framework is not only a response to the Land Commission but is a vital step toward achieving the ambitions set out in Southwark 2030.
16. Some of the risks without a clear Framework include:
- The 2023 Southwark Land Commission identified the lack of social purpose in land use planning as a critical challenge. Not adopting the Framework would represent a missed opportunity to act on this strategic recommendation and could undermine the credibility of the council's commitment to inclusive community land governance.
 - Without the Framework, there is an increased risk of inconsistent approaches across departments and projects, leading to inefficiencies and potential conflicts in land use priorities.
 - Not adopting the Framework could signal a lack of commitment to participatory governance, potentially eroding trust and reducing future community engagement.
17. The implementation of the pilot sites under the Social Purpose of Land Framework has financial implications on the council. As there is a need to avoid revenue and capital growth due to the wider council budgetary issues, it is proposed to utilise existing reserve funding.

POST DECISION IMPLEMENTATION

18. If the cabinet approves the recommendations, the following activities will be implemented:
- Update the Framework with feedback from cabinet and any essential updates from delivery teams.
 - Publish the Framework on the council's website.
 - Continue engagement with stakeholders in response to Framework.
 - Undertake the pilot projects with a view of using the learnings from the pilot as part of further refinement of the Framework in a future cabinet submission.
 - Outcomes from the pilot phase will be reported back to cabinet with recommendations for future application of the Framework including funding and governance implications.
 - Set up the SLP
 - Table the Framework at an inaugural meeting of the SLP meeting with other key landowners in the Borough.
 - Consider amendments to the Asset Management Plan.

BACKGROUND INFORMATION

19. As the first local authority-led Land Commission in London, it brought together residents, community organisations, landowners, and experts to explore how land could be used more fairly and effectively. The Commission's work was rooted in the belief that land should be a tool for public good, not just private

gain. The final report being the Land for Good, set out a bold vision for putting social purpose at the heart of land use, and called for new tools and policies to make that vision a reality.

20. The Council has committed to addressing the six key challenges within the Land for Good, including the insufficient focus on the social purpose of land. The report recommended that the council develop a Social Purpose of Land Framework to fairly balance social value with commercial income and help evaluate trade-offs that this may influence.
21. In February 2025, the council engaged the New Economics Foundation (NEF) to develop the Framework in collaboration with the Greater London Authority, council officers and the community. This work has been funded by the Greater London Authority with match council funding through senior officer engagement.
22. The Social Purpose of Land Framework is Southwark Council's proposed approach to making public land governance more transparent, equitable, and community led. The framework introduces participatory processes, including Neighbourhood Land Panel (NLPs), to evaluate and shape land use proposals. It will apply to specific council-identified pilot sites only, with guiding principles focused on transparency and accountability.
23. Social purpose as part of this framework seeks to address a local and strategic need, contributing to community wellbeing, equity and long-term public benefit. Importantly, social purpose does not imply that a use must be non-profit. Uses may be financially sustainable or income-generating, provided they align with identified social outcomes.
24. This cabinet decision relates only to the delivery of pilot sites using the Framework. However, the council remain committed to drawing on several recommendations made by NEF which will continue to inform the council's process design for future application of the Framework.
25. The Framework applies to specific council-owned assets (e.g., vacant land, surplus buildings, community spaces) but could also be applied to land/assets belonging to other partners. It draws on the original Land Commission proposal of NLPs to guide decision-making and uses a structured process.
26. The Framework is described below (and in accordance with Section 4 of **Appendix 1**) and will be applied to the pilot sites only:
 - a) Once recruited, NLPs will undertake a workshop (and potentially a walkabout) in each pilot neighbourhood to identify local priorities. A short "mission" statement is created by the NLP to guide land use decisions on each pilot site. NLPs should be recruited and facilitated in accordance with the Terms of Reference outlined in **Appendix 1**.
 - b) Public submissions are considered from members of the community through an online engagement platform and in person engagement event to inform the Asset Brief of the pilot sites. This is in addition to the Framework described in Section 4 of **Appendix 1**.

- c) The leading officer and council team draft an Asset Brief considering site constraints and other borough-wide policies (including the Community Plans for each neighbourhood). Council brief is subject to internal review and approvals before release. NLP reviews and must endorse the brief (2/3 majority).
- d) Council and NLPs invite expressions of interest from community groups, organisations, charities etc. on proposed uses and delivery models on the pilot sites.
- e) NLP evaluates proposals and submissions using the Desirability vs. Feasibility Matrix in **Appendix 1**.
- f) The NLP will make a formal recommendation on the preferred proposal to the responsible senior officer and cabinet member. The recommendation for each pilot site will be taken to cabinet for a formal decision, unless the decision can be made under delegated powers.
- g) The council retains final decision-making authority but must publish a formal response to the NLP's recommendation, including reasons for acceptance or rejection. If the recommendation is rejected, the NLP has the right to request an independent review, potentially led by another NLP.
- h) Selected proposals are implemented with agreed terms. Progress is monitored annually and publicly reported on council's website.

A more detailed outline of the process can be found in Section 4 of **Appendix 1**.

- 27. A number of different recruitment methods and approaches will be tested on each of the pilot sites to determine the best ways to promote participation across the borough.
- 28. The Land Commission findings also highlighted a need to leverage partnerships with public bodies, housing associations, and landowners to maximise land value for community benefit. The Commission recommended creating a dedicated partnership vehicle to bring together stakeholders, pool resources, and provide a transparent governance structure for land-based projects. This cabinet report also seeks endorsement to establish the SLP in accordance with the Terms of Reference in **Appendix 3**.
- 29. Feedback obtained as part of the work has also highlighted the importance of public confidence and openness in how land is acquired, disposed of, or developed. Currently, transparency is addressed through statutory notices and cabinet reports at key decision points. However, these measures often occur late in the process, limiting opportunities for early public engagement and scrutiny.
- 30. To strengthen trust and governance, this report also notes that as part of the review of the Asset Management Plan a mechanism to allow an early notification of the intent to dispose is considered. This is designed to increase

the awareness of the local community and interested stakeholders.

31. In establishing Neighbourhood Land Panels, we will draw on lessons from successful community-led initiatives such as the Resident Project Groups that have supported our New Homes programme. These groups have demonstrated the value of early engagement, transparent decision-making, and collaborative design processes. Similarly, the refurbishment of Walworth Town Hall has shown how involving local voices can create spaces that reflect community priorities while delivering high-quality outcomes. We will build on these examples to ensure Neighbourhood Land Panels become trusted forums for shaping development in a way that benefits residents and strengthens local identity.
32. While the NEF report and its recommendations have informed the development of the Framework in Section 4 and 5 of **Appendix 1** and in paragraph 26, it is important to note that the NEF's analysis and research in the remaining sections of their report does not represent the formal position or policy of Southwark Council. In proposing the recommendations in this report, the council has considered NEF's findings alongside its own priorities, statutory obligations, and operational requirements.
33. The council will undertake its own recruitment processes for NLPs and the appointment of a council officer, ensuring alignment with council procedures and governance standards. Publication of the NEF report is intended to support transparency, but does not imply wholesale adoption of all recommendations in relation to the future phases after the pilot (Section 6 of **Appendix 1**). The council will continue to refine the Framework, drawing on both the NEF's work and ongoing feedback from residents, partners, and internal teams.
34. The adoption of the Framework for the pilot sites and the associated activity will be carried out at the same time that the council is considering the creation of Community Review Panels for a number of neighbourhoods based on the Old Kent Road model. These are aimed at increasing community engagement in major developments at a pre-planning application stage.
35. It should be noted that the name "NLPs" will be reconsidered after cabinet, and it is not fixed. The council will determine if a more appropriate name is needed moving forward.

Strategic and service alignment

36. The Social Purpose of Land Framework and the Southwark 2030 strategy are closely aligned, both aiming to ensure that land and resources in the borough are used to benefit the community and promote equity, sustainability, and inclusion. The Framework supports all six (6) goals within Southwark 2030 by supporting the prioritisation of land use that delivers social value. This includes ensuring land supports environmental sustainability, community wellbeing and providing more affordable housing which is identified across a number of different goals of the 2030 Strategy. Land and assets can be used (and are needed) to achieve all of our Southwark 2030 goals.

37. The Social Purpose of Land Framework aligns closely with our ambitions around Neighbourhoods by increasing the transparency and community involvement in decisions taken locally. The Neighbourhoods model has progressed through the identification of the geographical neighbourhoods and subsequent neighbourhood meetings, the appointment of neighbourhood champions and officer coordinators, the start of the drafting of community plans and the formation of the Neighbourhood Grants Fund. By bringing forward pilot sites in a Neighbourhood context, we can test different models and use the built environment as a catalyst for greater engagement.
38. There is also significant cross-over with the voluntary and community sector (VCS) property strategy which is currently under review. The current policy is to charge market rent to all occupiers of the council's commercial estate including voluntary and community sector organisations.

Community engagement and co-delivery

39. Alongside targeted research, NEF undertook extensive community engagement through a number of different qualitative research methods. NEF's research was informed by 15 interviews with community leaders, Southwark Land Commissioners, council officers, local practitioners and wider civic landowners to understand the strengths and opportunities in developing the process. Further information including a summary of feedback has been provided in **Appendix 1**.
40. The council recognises that the local community have a wealth of relevant expertise and know the borough and what is needed. Three participatory land use workshops were undertaken involving residents of the borough to develop and define the parameters of this decision-tool. The research undertaken by NEF has informed the refinement of the Framework which takes this feedback into account.
41. NEF recruited community leaders through these interviews who have been involved in facilitating the land use workshops with the community, as well as participating in 1-to-1 conversations to build a further understanding of the community's perspective on land-use issues. This approach has allowed for learning outside of NEF, and supports future implementation and ownership of the Framework within the community.
42. A Southwark Advisory Group was established as part of the project to ensure the development of the Framework is informed by cross-council expertise, aligns with council priorities, and reflects the needs and aspirations of Southwark's communities. This group is made up of representatives from the following areas of council and externally:
 - Planning Policy
 - Property Services
 - Strategy and Communities
 - Sustainable Growth
 - Leisure
 - Stronger Neighbourhoods
 - Procurement

- Corporate Finance
- Law (Communities)
- Law (Property)
- Social Value – Local Economy
- Greater London Authority

43. A youth session took place on 19 November at the Westminster House Youth Club which focussed on asset mapping of spaces they value and want more of, and future visioning of what spaces for young people should look like. The activities were also intended to empower the group to contribute to the way spaces are used in a meaningful way and raise awareness of how they could participate on a NLP. This information has informed how the evaluation matrix of the framework could be applied and how we can best involve young people in the NLPs.

KEY ISSUES FOR CONSIDERATION

Governance

44. Whilst the usual council decision-making processes apply to the delivery of the Framework, via cabinet, planning committee and/or delegated powers, it is intended that there will also be the continued involvement of the Council Social Purpose of Land Advisory Group and the SLP to participate and oversee the delivery of the Framework.
45. As outlined in the framework in **Appendix 1**, council seeks to introduce a structured process involving new NLPs to ensure that residents and community organisations have meaningful influence over how council-owned land is used.
46. The NLPs will be central to the Framework's participatory approach. Each panel will involve a standing group made up of residents, community organisations, local businesses, ward councillors, and relevant council officers. NLPs will help shape the Asset Briefs and evaluate proposals for each pilot site. This ensures that decisions reflect locally agreed social priorities. While they do not replace formal planning powers, they will embed community voice early in the process and help build trust and accountability.
47. This Framework will precede the planning application stage as there may be circumstances where an Asset Brief and recommended proposal could be implemented without the need for planning permission.
48. The NLPs are not the decision-making body, as this stays with the planning committee, cabinet or senior officers depending on the proposal. The NLP can only make a recommendation to the council about how a pilot site will be delivered.
49. It is intended that the NLPs will align the processes under the existing Neighbourhoods Programme currently being coordinated by the Neighbourhoods Team. This programme involves existing Neighbourhoods meetings which aligns with the NLPs process. These meetings will be used to help identify local priorities and recruit the

NLPs.

50. A key outcome of the engagement activities informing this Framework is gaining interest in and recruiting the membership of the Southwark Land Partnership (SLP). The SLP will be convened in direct response to the recommendations of the 2023 Southwark Land Commission report, Land for Good.
51. The SLP will act as a collaborative forum to support the implementation of the Land Commission's recommendations, while also monitoring progress in implementing the Social Purpose of Land Framework. The terms of reference for this body is provided in **Appendix 3**.
52. As needs evolve, the governance structure will be reviewed to provide flexibility to ensure the Framework remains responsive to the changing needs of the local community.

Policy framework implications

53. The Framework is essential to the Southwark 2030 vision of building a fair, green and safe Southwark. The Framework supports all Southwark 2030 goals in one way or another, particularly the following:
 - ensuring that our town centres thrive and serve our local community
 - views of local people help shape their local areas
 - genuinely affordable homes will help towards addressing the housing crisis
 - reducing inequalities in health across our community
 - facilitating more green space and biodiversity across the borough.
54. In terms of planning applications that may be required on pilot sites these need to be determined in accordance with development plan including the London Plan (2021) and the Southwark Plan (2022) and all other relevant material considerations. The application of the framework and its outcome on each pilot site would have been subject to public engagement and the approval of the council. It will therefore have a degree of weight as an "other material consideration" which will need to be considered in the balance with adopted Development Plan policies and all other relevant material considerations at the time any planning application is determined. Consequently, the application of the Framework cannot predetermine the outcome of a planning application made on a pilot site.
55. The implementation of the pilot of the Framework it is unlikely to conflict with the ongoing Local Plan review process. Insights gathered through the pilot phase, including community engagement, asset briefs, and evaluation outcomes, will contribute to the development of the Local Plan. This evidence will be considered as part of a future cabinet decision on the wider application of the Framework, including its potential integration into planning policy and borough-wide land governance strategies.

Financial implications

56. Implementing the Framework will require dedicated financial resources including the following:
- One full-time officer to steward the process
 - Paid participation for community panel members
 - Internal coordination across different council teams
 - Survey and design work on the pilot sites.
57. While some costs are new, much of the work reframes existing activity to make it more transparent. Over time, the Framework may also unlock cost savings by reducing conflict, improving delivery outcomes, and aligning land use with long-term community needs.
58. The following provides a broad breakdown of the costs likely to be attributed to the pilots of the Framework.

Type of Cost	Unit Cost	Total Cost
Neighbourhood Land Panel Remuneration	London Living Wage rate x 3 meetings	£2,700
Full time employee remuneration	1 x £52,000 p/a	£52,000
Potential NLP Facilitation Cost	3 x £3,000 + VAT NLP meetings 1 x £2,500 + VAT governance and development sessions	£11,500
Feasibility and Design Studies	£100,000 - £180,000	Site dependant
TOTAL COST ESTIMATE		Approx. £100,000 (excluding VAT) per pilot site

*This does not include any income generated.

52. The source of funding for the Framework will utilise reserves budgets.

Pilot Sites

59. The council has identified four (4) council-owned sites for the initial pilot projects to apply the Framework. The pilot sites will involve the following:

Old Peckham Library, Peckham Hill Street	A council owned prefabricated building in poor structural condition occupies the majority of the site. The site was considered for council homes, but it is not a priority to take the site forward in the current programme.
Thorburn Square	This site which was included in Land For Good as a pilot site, owned by The Diocese of Southwark, is occupied by St Annes Church. A feasibility study commissioned by the Diocese

	has identified the potential to provide housing, a new worship space and community space.
Former Abbeyfield Housing Office, Rotherhithe New Road	This council owned building which used to provide office accommodation is currently occupied by Guardians. The site was considered for council homes at one point but it is not a priority to take the site forward in the current programme.
Community space at 177 Abbey Street	This new provision which is at the ground floor of a new council owned key workers housing scheme on Abbey Street is subject to planning permission. It is anticipated that the new facility, which will remain in council ownership, will be completed in 2028. The new facility replaces that previously provided by the Beormund Centre on this site.

60. A potential additional pilot site (fifth pilot site) has been identified as an inactive Tenant and Resident's Association Hall. Following further consultation, a report will be provided to the cabinet member for new homes and sustainable development for decision.
61. The council will apply the insights and learnings from the pilot site to inform the future development of the Framework.

Monitoring

62. The SLP will monitor the implementation of the Framework overtime. The council will provide regular reports on the application of the Framework to the SLP. The inaugural meeting of the SLP will involve establishing monitoring requirements.

Community, equalities (including socio-economic) and health impacts

Community impact statement

63. The Framework will enable meaningful engagement with the community as part of its application. Land across the borough needs to effectively serve underrepresented groups and seek to ensure that more land in Southwark is used for the benefit of the local community. For this reason, the Framework considers the needs of all people and reflects the needs and priorities of people with different protected characteristics and help mitigate against any potential negative impacts that could arise. It will also help promote good community relations and highlight opportunities to tackle inequality.
64. The Framework is provided in an accessible format that will be published online and can be printed if needed. To ensure that as wide a range of people can engage with the Framework, the following engagement channels will be utilised where appropriate:

- Forums and networks
- Local community and resident groups
- Council business e-newsletter
- Council website, social media and publications

Equalities (including socio-economic) impact statement

65. To ensure a fairer, stronger economy, the Framework must reflect the needs and priorities of people from a range of socio-economic backgrounds.
66. The public sector equality duty (“PSED”) is set out in section 149 of the Equality Act 2010 (“2010 Act”). The PSED requires public authorities, in the carrying out of their functions, to have due regard to the need to eliminate unlawful discrimination, harassment and victimisation and other conduct prohibited by the 2010 Act, advance equality of opportunity between persons who share a protected characteristic and persons who do not share it, and foster good relations between persons who share a relevant protected characteristic and persons who do not share it.
67. A full equality impact and needs analysis (EINA) has been undertaken for the Framework and is attached in **Appendix 2**. This considers the potential positive and negative impacts of the Framework on people with different protected characteristics such as age, disability and race. The EINA considers the wider impacts of the Framework on those persons with protected characteristics and people who are socio-economically disadvantaged. The assessment undertaken found that the Framework has strong objectives for improving the quality of life for underrepresented people including improving access to decision making functions in council, fostering community cohesion, improving health and equal opportunities for all. It concludes that there are no negative impacts arising from the Framework.

Health impact statement

68. To ensure that the needs and priorities of people with health conditions are reflected in the implementation of the Framework, all engagement channels outlined above will be utilised.
69. The positive health impacts from the Framework are well documented in **Appendix 2**.

Climate change implications

70. The Framework will be published online to reduce paper generated by printing. However, the documents will be printable on request to ensure full accessibility.
71. A key outcome of the Framework is the inclusion of environmental sustainability as part of the considerations to inform a decision of how land could be used. This seeks to improve the sustainability of the local environment.

Resource implications

72. An additional dedicated officer resource is required and will be responsible for:
- Developing a project plan for the pilot
 - Facilitating the delivery of the Framework
 - Monitoring the progress of the Framework, ensuring compliance with the council's overarching economic development, environmental and social value goals.
73. The proposal is to allocate up to £0.5m of reserve funding to the Social Purpose of Land Framework.
74. This proposal can be accommodated from existing reserve balances.

Consultation

75. The Framework has been informed by non-statutory, informal engagement with a number of key stakeholders within the borough including as stated in paragraphs 39 to 43. This feedback has driven the objectives and vision of the Framework. A summary of the feedback provided is included in **Appendix 1**.

The feedback on the research undertaken by NEF and the proposed Framework from the consultees and stakeholders has been constructive and positive. There were some clear themes such as:

- Lack of clarity of legal, financial and governance arrangements currently forming part of the operation of council.
 - The risks to council income and programmes from reduced commercial rents and/or reuse of council assets.
 - Significant council resources being required to delivery on the research undertaken by NEF.
 - Social benefits must balance with financial planning and income.
 - Framework must align with Southwark 2030 and Local Plan processes.
 - Governance structure should be clear including decision making process confirmed.
 - Panel membership may not reflect the views of all stakeholders in a community.
76. A number of changes were made to the Framework to reflect this feedback including (but not limited to):
- A clear acknowledgement the Framework does not conflict with the financial and governance arrangements currently forming part of the operation of council.
 - Clearer processes for NLP membership and the neighbourhood level engagement open for all residents to avoid misrepresentation of a community.
 - Pulling back to introduce only four pilot sites in order to test and learn lessons on the application of the Framework.

77. The council acknowledges that there is valuable experience and knowledge

amongst the community and further stakeholder engagement will continue throughout the implementation of the Framework due to the nature of its application. Feedback will continue to be captured as it useful and could be applied as part of further refinement of the Framework post-pilot phase.

SUPPLEMENTARY ADVICE FROM OTHER OFFICERS

Strategic Director of Resources (FIN25 – 32)

78. This report seeks cabinet approval to the Social Purpose of Land Framework and the eight stated recommendations which are detailed at the outset of this report.
79. The strategic director of resources notes the contents of the report, the post approval implementation programme and the forecast expenditure by category as detailed in the financial implications.
80. It is also noted that cabinet is asked to approve the release of £500k from reserves in relation to funding this programme.
81. As detailed in the financial implications the future programme expenditure will be regularly reviewed and capitalised as appropriate.

Assistant Chief Executive, Governance and Assurance (KD – 12/12/25)

82. The cabinet is asked to:
 - Approve the implementation of the Social Purpose of Land Framework ('the Framework') pilot phase as set out in Section 4 and 5 (page 39 to 50 of Appendix 1 – Social Purpose of Land Framework a Proposal from The New Economics Foundation, and paragraph 26 of this report, on four (4) council-identified sites as set out in paragraph 59.
 - Note that a revised Framework will be brought back to cabinet following the pilot phase for further consideration.
 - Delegate the approval of any minor non-substantive amendments resulting from its meeting and a final review by officers on the Framework to the director of planning and growth in consultation with the cabinet member for new homes and sustainable development prior to final release.
 - Delegate authority to the director of planning and growth to oversee implementation and refinement of the Framework processes, including the development of an Action Plan supporting the framework.
 - Establish the Southwark Land Partnership (SLP) in accordance with the Terms of Reference in Appendix 3 and delegate authority to the director of planning and growth to finalise governance arrangements and partnership agreements.

- Consider whether to issue early notice of the intention to dispose of Council's owned land or buildings at the time of reviewing the Asset Management Plan.
- Agree an allocation of £500,000 of reserve funding towards the costs of informing and resourcing the pilot sites of the Social Purpose of Land Framework.

This is to be approved by the cabinet in accordance with the Part 3B of the council's constitution.

83. The Equality Act 2010 introduced the public sector equality duty (PSED), which merged existing race, sex and disability equality duties and extended them to include other protected characteristics; namely age, gender reassignment, pregnancy and maternity, religion and belief, and sex and sexual orientation, including marriage and civil partnership.

In summary those subject to the equality duty, which includes the council, must in the exercise of their functions:

- (i) have due regard to the need to eliminate unlawful discrimination, harassment and victimisation; and
- (ii) foster good relations between people who share a protected characteristic and those who do not.

84. The officers carried out the EINA which is set out in the Appendix 2. The impact the proposed recommendations may have on those with protected characteristics is considered as part of this report and in the EINA.
85. Officers have concluded that the proposals are not considered to have any adverse impacts on persons with protected characteristics and will advance equality of opportunity.
86. The Human Rights Act 1998 imposed a duty on the council as a public authority to apply the European Convention on Human Rights; as a result, the council must not act in a way that is incompatible with these rights. The most important rights for planning purposes are Article 8 (respect for homes), Article 6 (natural justice) and Article 1 of the First Protocol (peaceful enjoyment of property). Officers consider that the implementation of the proposals contained in this report have been considered in the EINA and the officers conclude that this will not result in the council acting in the way that is incompatible with the European Convention.
87. Council Assembly on 14 July 2021 approved a change to the council's constitution to confirm that all decisions made by the council will consider the climate and equality (including socio-economic disadvantage and health inequality) consequences of taking that decision. This has been considered in this report at paragraph 65 to 71.

88. Whilst there is no requirement to consult the public on the production of this strategy, the report identifies the extensive engagement which informed the Framework and the continued engagement that will follow when giving effect to the Framework.
89. The cabinet will note the informal extensive consultation that has been carried out in connection with the proposals. It is necessary as a matter of law for the cabinet to carefully take account of the outcome of this consultation as set out in the report in reaching its conclusions on this item.
90. The principles of fair consultation have been followed, and officers have reviewed the outcome of the consultation, making any necessary amendments before recommending a revised recommendations to the cabinet.

BACKGROUND DOCUMENTS

Background Papers	Held At	Contact
None.		

APPENDICES

No.	Title
Appendix 1	Social Purpose of Land Framework – New Economics Foundation Report
Appendix 2	Equality Impact and Needs Analysis
Appendix 3	Southwark Land Partnership Terms of Reference

AUDIT TRAIL

Cabinet Member	Councillor Helen Dennis, New Homes and Sustainable Development		
Lead Officer	Neil Kirby, Assistant Director, Sustainable Growth		
Report Author	Lauren Mudd, Regeneration Programme Manager, Sustainable Growth		
Version	Final		
Dated	17 December 2025		
Key Decision?	Yes		
CONSULTATION WITH OTHER OFFICERS / DIRECTORATES / CABINET MEMBER			
Officer Title	Comments Sought	Comments Included	
Assistant Chief Executive, Governance and Assurance	Yes	Yes	
Head of Legal Planning and Property	Yes	Yes	
Divisional Accountant	Yes	Yes	
Cabinet Member	Yes	Yes	
Date final report sent to Constitutional Team		17 December 2025	